



China's early dynasties

According to Chinese tradition, the first Chinese rulers were the Xia Dynasty, though archaeologists disagree on whether this dynasty existed or not. The Xia are believed to have governed a kingdom on the banks of the Yellow River in the late 3rd to early 2nd millennium BCE. The Xia were later followed by the Shang, the Zhou, and eventually the Qin.

BEFORE 500 CE

RISE AND FALL OF DYNASTIES

c. 1600–1046 BCE

The Shang kings rule a small northern state, which soon expands to control a large part of China. They use animal bones, covered with ancient Chinese script, that are believed to tell the future. Shang metalworkers master the crafting of bronze items.



SHANG TORTOISE SHELL WITH WRITING

1046–776 BCE



ZHOU GOOSE-SHAPED RITUAL VESSEL

In 1046 BCE, the Shang are overthrown by King Wu of Zhou, who founds his own dynasty.

The Zhou kings claim they have been given the right to rule by heaven. This concept of the "Mandate of Heaven" is used by all later Chinese emperors.

776–221 BCE

From 776 BCE onward, the Zhou kings struggle to control the different parts of the kingdom, which disintegrates into many separate states constantly at war with one another. From 476 to 221 BCE, only seven states remain, and the most western state, Qin, conquers the others one by one.

221–210 BCE

The king of Qin, who names himself Shi Huangdi (First Emperor), uses force to unify China, making everyone adopt the same writing script, coinage, and measuring units. But the power of the Qin weakens dramatically after his death in 210 BCE, and the dynasty is overthrown just four years later.

◀ TERRA-COTTA ARMY

The First Emperor was buried in a vast tomb built by 700,000 workers. To the east of the tomb, pits held an army of at least 8,000 life-size terra-cotta warriors, created to protect the emperor in the next world.